negotiating the Dhipu-la, dropped down to a lake before reaching Hot Springs in the Di Chu Valley (a two-day march). It would take a further two days to reach Kahoo, from where the track followed the Di Chu to the Sangam at Kibithu where it was connected to the western track by a steel rope bridge.

Kibithu lay 190 kilometres from the road head near Tezu. With even mules stubbornly refusing to negotiate them, both the western and eastern tracks were rarely used either by the Assam Rifles personnel or the army, which inducted 2 Rajput under the command of Lieutenant Colonel M. S. Rikh into Walong towards the end of 1959. The battalion was then a part of 5 Infantry Brigade that had its Brigade HQ in Aalong. A small grass strip had been constructed on the west bank of the Lohit at Walong on which small Otter aircraft could land and take off. These aircraft, along with airdrops by other transport aircraft of the IAF, were the lifeline that supported the entire garrison at Walong and the forward posts at Kibithu.

Captain Ashok Kalyan Verma moved in with the first company of 2 Rajput into Walong after the battalion had detrained at Missamari and spent a few months doing jungle training at Charduar. After a harrowing flight and an equally frightening landing at Walong, he recalls:

> At Walong the river divided the battalion's deployment into two halves. One could only get to the companies on the east side by crossing the 800-foot-wide river suspended upside down on a half-inch thick steel cable. This frightening contraption was called the 'twine' and it consisted of a small wooden piece to which one was lashed onto with raw leather straps.
>
> Having gone ahead of the battalion, the initial reconnaissance of Walong was done by me. I would later be associated with the construction of the defences and bunkers. There was plenty of pine for timber and we had ample time at our disposal. It was great fun toiling with the men. As the other companies started arriving and machine guns got allotted, the work expanded. We also made our own small arms ranges and fired our weapons to stay in practice. Altogether, a very typical period of infantry work. Being separated by the river and the terrain, we officers were left very much on our own.

The most prominent feature in the Walong Sector is Point (PT) 14470, about sixteen kilometres to the northwest. Short of the feature was Trijunction (13,250 feet); to its immediate east were the connecting spurs of Yellow Pimple and Green Pimple—the three features together forming a triangle with Yellow Pimple being the northern apex. While facing north, to the right of Green Pimple were Patrol Base, the Maha Plateau, Mithun and finally The Ladders on the western track to Kibithu itself. On the east bank of the river were High Plateau, Dong Hill, Dong Peak and Dakota Hill. Other prominent landmarks in the immediate vicinity of Walong were the